A1g. Reflective Report

IDEA9106 Design Thinking

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Project: Message Drift

Introduction

This reflective report will draw on Bassot's (2013) Integrated Reflective Cycle to discuss what I learned in IDEA9106 through the Message Drift group project and the A1a–A1f mindset and peer evaluation assignments. It will reflect on how my ability to adapt to uncertainty has evolved, how peer evaluation has influenced my understanding of teamwork, and how design thinking supports my future learning and professional practice.

Comfort with ambiguity

At first, I struggled to adapt to the open-ended design brief for IDEA9106 because it offered no fixed answers and required us to identify the problem, user needs, and design direction on our own. Later, through discussion, trial and error, and testing, I began to understand that ambiguity is not an obstecle, but rather an opportunity to redefine the problem.

This uncertainty was evident in our early concept for a "cultural exchange corridor." This direction came from interview findings, where some participants expressed interest in cultural connections. However, we later realised that "culture" was too broad, sensitive, and diffcult to represent accurately. If we relied solely on cultural symbols or patterns, the project risked becoming superficial and could even lead to misunderstandings or offence. Therefore, we shifted our focus from "cultural display" to the more specific concept of "student connection," which evolved into "Message Drift."

Low-fidelity prototypes and testing helped me become more comfortable with uncertainty. Through cardboard walls, anonymous message bottles, mobile interactions, and lighting simulations, we transformed abstract ideas into tangible installations. Tester feedback revealed that while anonymous messages and bottle feedback were appealing, the tokens were confusing, and the meeting/time-slot system created stress. Consequently, we needed to simplify interactions, add guidance, and provide users with clearer choices.

I also gained inspiration by testing other teams' prototypes, seeing how the same brief could yield different outcomes. Overall, I learned that ambiguity cannot be completely eliminated, but it can be managed through reframing, prototyping, user

feedback, and group discussions. In the future, when faced with an unclear direction, I will first move forward with small-scale testing rather than rushing to determine the final answer.

Peer evaluation

Peer evaluation helped me realise that design thinking isn't achieved solely through individual creativity or the final outcome, but rather relies on division of labour, communication, feedback, and collaboration. Previously, I focused more on whether the prototype and presentation were completed, but through peer evaluation, I began to pay attention to each member's contributions throughout the process, and how those contributions influenced the overall quality of the design.

In the Message Drift project, different team members took on different roles. Some were responsible for organising meetings, assigning tasks, and monitoring progress; others handled idea generation and concept development; some managed visual presentation, key design deliverables, and communication with the tutor; and still others consistently completed their tasks or handled final checks to ensure the final content addressed the brief. By evaluating these contributions, I realised that teamwork isn't about who does the most, but rather how different roles collectively support the design process.

Peer evaluation also helped me understand the role of constructive feedback. It's not just about assigning scores or listing strengths; rather, it helps me identify which collaborative approaches are effective and where improvements are needed. While meeting deadlines is important, actively participating in discussions, proposing design ideas, and promptly raizing issues are equally crucial. A good design thinking team cannot rely solely on task assignments; it also requires members to collectively determine direction and drive iteration.

Through the feedback received for A1b, A1d, and A1f, I gained a clearer understanding of my contributions in terms of organisation, communication, meeting deadlines, and supporting project progress. At the same time, it reminded me that in the future, I can be more proactive in offering design insights during the early stages of idea generation and concept development. Overall, peer evaluation has shown me that effective teamwork is not about an equal division of labour, but rather about different members leveraging their strengths at the appropriate stages and contineuously adjusting their contributions through feedback.

Future Design Thinking application

This course has made me realise that design thinking is not just a method for generating ideas, but also a way of thinking that allows us to gradually understand problems, validate directions, and refine solutions when information is incomplete. In the future, when faced with open-ended tasks, I won't rush to finalise a concept; instead, I'll first gather information to understand the context, location, users, and existing case studies, thereby establishing a basic understanding of the problem.

I will continue to use sketchnoting, preliminery research, interviews, and feedback to process complex information. Secondary sources and sketchnoting help me organise the context, relationships, and opportunities, while interviews help me uncover users' initial interests, needs, and concerns. In the Message Drift project, we initially discovered through interviews that students were interested in "cultural connection," which led us to propose the "cultural display" or "cultural corridor" direction. However, during the presentation and group feedback sessions, we realised that "cultural expression" might be too broad and carry the risk of misunderstanding or offence. This feedback helped us rethink the problem, shifting our focus from directly showcasing culture to the safer, more focused concept of "student connection."

I will also continue to use HMW and problem reframing. HMW helps me translate research and feedback into more actionable design questions, while reframing reminds me not to lock in a direction too early. If a project is too broad, even an interesting concept may fail to address real needs. Therefore, in the future, I will pay closer attention to ensuring that the design direction remains aligned with research insights and feedback, rather than relying solely on my own assumptions.

Finally, low-fidelity prototyping and user testing are the methods I'm most eager to continue using. Low-fidelity prototypes have taught me that the value of early models lies not in their polished appearance, but in allowing users to understand, experience, and evaluate the core idea. Through testing, designers can uncover issues they hadn't anticipated and continue to iterate. Moving forward, I'll place greater emphasis on using user feedback to inform design decisions, rather than relying solely on subjective judgment.

Conclusion

Overall, this course helped me understand design thinking as a continuous process of exploration, validation, and refinement. Through reflecting on ambiguity, peer evaluation, and the Message Drift project, I learned to redefine problems under uncertainty, appreciate the value of different team roles, and use low-fidelity prototypes and user feedback to improve future design decisions.

Individual contribution statement

I made significant contributions to the group project through coordination, communication, concept development, and project organisation. Throughout the project, I actively participated in group discussions, asked questions, shared suggestions, and helped ensure that our concepts addressed the brief and research insights.

I also facilitated communication within the group. Since our team members had different language backgrounds, I assisted with translation and interpretation between Chinese and English when needed. This was crucial for ensuring everyone understood the discussion topics, assignment requirements, tutor feedback, and each member's responsibilities.

Additionally, I helped organise meetings, assign tasks, and track progress. During the prototyping and presentation phases, I helped clarify each person's responsibilities and reminded the group when tasks were missing or needed improvement. When team members needed support, I also helped explain tasks or specific sections to keep the group's work moving smoothly. I consistently completed my own assigned tasks on time for every assessment.

Overall, my role extended beyond simply completing my own tasks to include supporting the team's organisation, communication, and project quality. I helped the team stay on track and ensured our work consistently met the requirements of the brief.

AI Appendix

I used ChatGPT to help organise the report's structure, polish the English wording, and ensure that my reflections clearly addressed the assignment prompts. The final arguments, project examples, and personal reflections were all selected, revised, and finalised by me based on my own learning experiences.

Reference list

Bassot, B. (2013). *The reflective journal.* Palgrave Macmillan.